HCP 1536 (pc_hcp_217): a Czech postcard to Anna Tichá, St Wenceslas 1903

Human solver: Tomáš Pavuk

Status: deciphered in full (393 cipher signs, 395 letters). Three signs are partly hidden by the printed picture and one is restored. Independent review 1 gave the verdict REVISE; all five findings were fixed, and one letter changed. Report dated 2026-10-29.

Origin and context

The cryptogram is record 1536 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1536), portal name pc_hcp_217. It belongs to the HCPortal collection of cryptographic postcards (private collection). When the record was captured on 2026-10-28, the portal listed it as **Not solved**: tagged Postcard and HCPortal collection, category Substitution, date 1903-09-26, language Czech, sender Unknown, recipient Anna Tichá. No transcription or solution was attached.

The card is an artist's picture postcard with three red cherries on a branch. The publisher's line reads "Meissner & Buch, Leipzig. 12 Künstler-Postkarten Serie 1212. Aus dem Obstgarten." The card is scanned sideways. Turned upright (90° clockwise), it shows nine cipher rows below the cherries (B01–B09), ending with the plain date **26./IX.1903.** (Saturday, 26 September 1903). Two more cipher rows (M01–M02) run up the right-hand edge; they read upright when the scan is turned 180°.

The address side is written in plain: **Velectěná Slečna / slečna Anna Tichá / učitelka v / Žirovnici / u Počátek.** ("Honoured Miss Anna Tichá, teacher in Žirovnice near Počátky", South Bohemia). The Austrian 5-heller stamp is cancelled **PRAHA 7**. An inverted arrival postmark ŽIROVNICE / SEROWITZ shows day 27 and year 03 clearly; its month is faint.

The card belongs to a family of cipher postcards to Anna Tichá. They are in the same hand and the same cipher, and those that are signed are signed "Pepouš", a pet form of Josef. Many of them are deciphered in this repository (for example HCP 1520–1527, 1545 and 1556). The key was **transferred unchanged** from those cards (compare ciphers/hcp-1545/work/key.json). A partial key for the family had been published earlier by Maxim Egorov (https://maxim-egorov.dev/research/anna-ticha-postcards/). This card was therefore read with a known key; the key was not recovered from it. No earlier reading of this particular card was found or consulted.



Picture side turned upright: nine cipher rows below the cherries ending with the date 26./IX.1903, and two margin rows up the right edge (work/picture_cw.png)



Address side: Anna Tichá, teacher in Žirovnice near Počátky; PRAHA 7 cancellation on the stamp, ŽIROVNICE arrival postmark at the centre left (source/address.jpg)

The card carries no other cipher text. The remaining marks are the plain date, the address, the printed postcard headings, the publisher's line, the stamp and postmarks, and the HCPortal watermark.

Method

The transcription was made **by hand**, not by OCR. The nine main rows were read from the picture turned clockwise, and the two margin rows from the picture turned 180°. Every sign was read from enlarged crops of each row (work/panel-B01.png … panel-M02.png, each with a position legend). The record is generated by work/build_record.py into work/transcription.json; every sign, space and punctuation mark has an index. Similar shapes were compared with other occurrences on the same card. For example, the last word of B03 contains the hooked q/Z sign, not the angular 7-shaped y/J sign (work/q-vs-y-same-card.png), which gives ODLOZITI.

The family key decodes every sign of this card into connected Czech, with no unknown or unused sign. One command, run from the repository root, checks the hashes of the source images, the key and the record, decodes the record, re-encodes it sign by sign as a check, and prints the plaintext:

```
python3 ciphers/hcp-1536/work/decode.py
```

The command uses only the standard library; SOLUTION.md gives the full interpreter path used. Its output reports 11 rows and 393 keyed signs (2 of them CH signs), which give 395 letters. The two flagged places are printed in brackets.

In review, a separate agent rotated and cropped the scan itself and checked every row sign by sign at 3×, and the hard places at up to 14×. It decoded the record with its own script, which builds the key from a sister card. Its output matched the solver's for all eleven rows.

Key

Monoalphabetic substitution. The labels are conventional names for the handwritten shapes. Note the pairs: m = N and n = M; crossed t = D and looped d = T; round c = S and angular s = C; b = P and p = B. y is the angular 7-shaped J sign, and H is an r-shape with a small caron, which stands for the digraph CH.

Shape	Plain	Shape	Plain	Shape	Plain	Shape	Plain
1	Y	2	U	3	O	4	I
5	E	6	A	8	L	y	J
b	P	c	S	d	T	f	V
g	K	h	R	m	N	n	M
p	B	q	Z	r	H	s	C
t	D	H	CH				

Czech diacritics are not encoded; the cipher writes base letters only.

Sign frequencies (393 in all): 1:4, 2:18, 3:34, 4:34, 5:36, 6:38, 8:15, b:9, c:28, d:20, f:21, g:13, h:16, m:23, n:16, p:2, q:16, r:7, s:10, t:23, y:8, H:2.

Plaintext

Ciphertext as transcribed:

```
B01 d4c4s5h1 t4g, t2c4mg3 n3y5, q6 th6r5 bc6mg3, gd5h5
B02 nm5 f584s5 b3d5c483. d6g5 y6 fqb3n4m6n fh585 m6
B03 83mcg5r3 cf6d5r3 f6s86f6. n2c48 yc5n 3t83q4d4
B04 cf3y4 s5cd2 t3 2cd4 m6c85tg5n d3r3, q5 m6c fhHm4
B05 cbh6fs5 n2c48 fs5h6 3t3y5d4 m6 2h5tm4 g3n4cc4
B06 t3 H3sm5. b3y5t2 m1m4 rm5t 3tc2t q 2h6t2, gt5
B07 n6n y4q cf6 q6f6q6t86. p2t2 nm3r3 fqb3n4m6d4
B08 m6 cf32 q86d32 6m2cg2, gd5h32 fh585 qth6f4n 6
B09 d4c4sgh6d5 84p6n.
M01 3t5c486n 84cd5g y4q q bh6r1, b3m5f6tq b3cd3fm4
M02 s5cd6 q 2cd4 t3 q4h3fm4s5 dhf6 6c4 tf6 tm1.
```

Literal Czech, as decoded. Base letters only; [brackets] mark the partly hidden and restored signs (see Uncertainties):

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B01 TISICERY DIK, DUSINKO MO[J][E][,] ZA DRAHE PSANKO, KTERE
B02 MNE VELICE POTESILO. TAKE JA VZPOMINAM VRELE NA
B03 LONSKEHO SVATEHO VACLAVA. MUSIL JSEM ODLOZITI
B04 SVOJI CESTU DO USTI NASLEDKEM TOHO, ZE NAS VRCHNI
B05 SPRAVCE MUSIL VCERA ODOJETI NA UREDNI KOMISSI
B06 DO CHOCNE. POJEDU NYNI HNED ODSUD Z URADU, KDE
B07 MAM JIZ SVA ZAVAZADLA. BUDU MNOHO VZPOMINATI
B08 NA SVOU ZLATOU ANUSKU, KTEROU VRELE ZDRAVIM A
B09 TISICKRATE LIBAM.
M01 ODESILAM LISTEK JIZ Z PRA[H]Y, PONEVADZ POSTOVNI
M02 CESTA Z USTI DO ZIROVNICE TRVA ASI DVA DNY.
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Normalized Czech (diacritics and capitals are editorial; the writer's forms odojeti and komissi are kept):

Tisícerý dík, dušinko moje, za drahé psánko, které mne velice potěšilo. Také já vzpomínám vřele na loňského svatého Václava. Musil jsem odložiti svoji cestu do Ústí následkem toho, že náš vrchní správce musil včera odojeti na úřední komissi do Chocně. Pojedu nyní hned odsud z úřadu, kde mám již svá zavazadla. Budu mnoho vzpomínati na svou zlatou Anušku, kterou vřele zdravím a tisíckráte líbám.

Odesílám lístek již z Prahy, poněvadž poštovní cesta z Ústí do Žirovnice trvá asi dva dny.

English translation: **A thousand thanks, my darling, for your dear little letter, which pleased me very much. I too remember last year's St Wenceslas' Day warmly. I had to postpone my journey to Ústí, because yesterday our chief administrator had to leave for an official commission in Choceň. I shall go now, straight from the office, where I already have my luggage. I shall think a great deal of my golden Anuška, whom I greet warmly and kiss a thousand times.**

I am sending the card from Prague already, because the post from Ústí to Žirovnice takes about two days.

Slovak translation: **Tisícoraká vďaka, dušička moja, za drahý lístoček, ktorý ma veľmi potešil. Aj ja vrúcne spomínam na minuloročného svätého Václava. Musel som odložiť svoju cestu do Ústí, pretože náš hlavný správca musel včera odcestovať na úradnú komisiu do Chocne. Pôjdem teraz hneď odtiaľto z úradu, kde už mám svoju batožinu. Budem veľa spomínať na svoju zlatú Anušku, ktorú srdečne pozdravujem a tisíckrát bozkávam.**

Lístok posielam už z Prahy, pretože poštová cesta z Ústí do Žirovnice trvá asi dva dni.

Notes on the reading:

- **Svatý Václav.** St Wenceslas' Day, 28 September, falls two days after the date on the card. The writer remembers the same feast a year earlier, presumably a day the two spent together.
- **Ústí and Choceň.** Choceň is a small town in eastern Bohemia, and Ústí is most likely the nearby Ústí nad Orlicí. The writer planned to travel there, but had to wait because his superior (vrchní správce, "chief administrator") was away on an official commission. The margin explains why the card was posted in Prague: from Ústí it would take about two days to reach Žirovnice. This agrees with the PRAHA 7 cancellation and the Žirovnice arrival postmark of the 27th.
- **Period forms.** *musil* (for musel), *odložiti*, *vzpomínati*, *tisíckráte* and *komissi* with -ss- are normal Czech spellings around 1900. *Odojeti* (for odjeti, "to leave") is clearly written that way and is kept as the writer's form.
- **Anuška, dušinko** ("little soul", i.e. darling) are terms of endearment, as on the sister cards.

Uncertainties

- **MOJE, (B01).** The tops of the three signs after MO are hidden by the printed red cherry. Their lower parts are visible: the angular descender of the J sign (as in JSEM and ODOJETI on the same card, and unlike the hooked Z), the lower bowl of an E, and a long slanting stroke. The baseline is visible across the whole span, and no other sign fits there. The reading JE therefore rests on the visible strokes, and the vocative "dušinko moje" agrees with it. The final stroke is longer than this writer's other commas, so it is only a probable comma.
- **The R of PRAHY (M01).** Between PRA… and Y the sign is not visible: it is under the printed leaf stem or extremely faint. R is restored from the sense and from the PRAHA 7 postmark.
- **The arrival postmark** shows day 27 and year 03 clearly; its month is faint. The reviewer read it as IX.
- **Which Ústí** is meant is not stated; Ústí nad Orlicí is likely because of Choceň.
- **The sender** is not named on this card. The hand, the cipher and the recipient match the cards signed "Pepouš".
- **The scan** is only 1024×674 px, which limits fine stroke detail.
- Accents and capitals in the normalized text are editorial.
- The key was transferred from the family, not recovered from this card; it decodes every sign here without change.

Review summary

Reviewer: a separate Claude Opus 5.5 agent (Anthropic), round 1, verdict **REVISE**. The reviewer ran the reproduction command and decoded the record with its own script, using a key built from a sister card; the results were identical. It checked every row against the scan at 3× and the hard places at up to 14×, and judged the Czech to be natural for the period and consistent with the date, the places and the postmarks. It found no undisclosed use of a published solution. Its five findings and what changed:

1. **ODESILAM, not ODSILAM (major).** A full E sign stands between the D and the S of the first margin word; the transcription had missed it, and the earlier text had treated "odsílám" as the writer's unusual spelling. Fixed: the record now has the E, and the reading is odesílám. This is the only change of a letter.
2. **MOJE was not in the record (major).** The completed word had been argued in SOLUTION.md, but the record and the command output still showed an unknown-length gap. Fixed: the signs are recorded as J, E and a probable comma, flagged as partly obscured, and the command prints them.
3. **R of PRAHY not visible (minor).** Now disclosed as a restored sign and flagged in the record and the output.
4. **Postmarks (minor).** The PRAHA 7 and Žirovnice postmarks are now used as independent evidence for "already from Prague".
5. **Stale status text (minor).** Notes left over from the earlier, partial stage were marked as superseded.

Credit. An OpenAI GPT solver did the manual transcription, the key transfer, the decoder and the first partial reading on 2026-10-28. Claude Opus 5.5 read the obscured word, responded to the review and wrote this report on 2026-10-29. A separate Claude Opus 5.5 agent carried out the independent review.

Sources

- HC Portal record 1536, General, Description and Attachments tabs, captured 2026-10-28: https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1536 (source/metadata.md).
- Picture side: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/4668/conversions/pc_hcp_217_pic-large.jpg (source/picture.jpg).
- Address side: https://api.hcportal.eu/media/4669/conversions/pc_hcp_217_adr-large.jpg (source/address.jpg).
- Family key: Anna Tichá cards in this repository (ciphers/hcp-1520, ciphers/hcp-1545).
- Maxim Egorov, Anna Tichá postcards, published partial family key: https://maxim-egorov.dev/research/anna-ticha-postcards/
- AI Decipherment Register (https://ai.hcportal.eu/register/), checked 2026-10-29: no entry for this card.